

Outline an evaluation strategy related to the selection and purchase of new software. Relate this to your own school.

You have been tasked with training a large group of teachers at your school with a wide range of skills in a short time. Describe your plan to implement this training. Don't forget to include 2 outside sources to support your discussion.

In today's educational institutions, operations are not much different from business operations, and these include everything from student enrollment to institutional sustainability. Large or small organizations depend on technology to keep these kinds of operations running smoothly and uninterrupted.

Technology not only improves teaching and learning but also enhances communication and collaboration, providing the tools and techniques that streamline business processes and operations. Technology is a general term for hardware, software, the Internet, mobile devices, wireless technologies, and other technological solutions. Hardware solutions describe the configuration of servers, desktop computers, and network infrastructure, while software solutions are application software that is geared toward specific business functions. Both the hardware and software technologies enable and power the Internet. Many of today's application software are browser-based and run via the Internet.

There are just too many different types of hardware and software configurations from many vendors, and choosing the right solution is a challenge for both business and educational organizations. There is the right hardware and software solution for just about any type of organization. If the right solution is found, it helps streamline business processes and operations. Likewise, the costs are just too high if the wrong solution is selected. Many hardware and software providers promise dramatic improvements in business processes with their solution, but this is just another sales pitch. Is technology making our life easier? Yes.

Many colleges and universities use the same technologies for teaching, learning, and communication that technology companies use. Recently, here at Ohlone College, there have been many emails to all employees about new software installations and updates. For many organizations, new software installations, software updates, new hardware, etc., are normal activities, and it's an ongoing process.

For educational institutions, I think that the school administrator needs to involve the stakeholders, students, faculty, staff, and employees in their decision about new software or new technology of any kind.

That is why choosing the right kind of software (or hardware) is so important, and software evaluation is an essential part of any new application software to ensure it meets the needs of all stakeholders. The good news is that there is a process for evaluating software, and each company has a different one to meet its needs.

You have seen the development of instructional design. The software evaluation process is not very different. At Oracle Corporation, software evaluation is the process of determining how well and to what extent commercially available software, which has generally been developed and supported by other users, can satisfy the needs. Here is my strategy for software evaluation:

- 1) Software needs
- 2) Put together a team
- 3) Identifying/screening/reference-check vendors to consider
- 4) Development processes – identify and evaluate the needs (requirements, prototype, development, test, and deploy).

Here are a few good links on software evaluations that align with my thinking.

Komoski, P. Kenneth (1995), Seven Steps to Responsible Software Selection. ERIC Digest from <http://www.ericdigests.org/1996-1/seven.htm>

Best Practices: Software Evaluation For Mid-Sized Organizations from http://www.harrisdata.com/documents/business_credit.pdf

Software Evaluation, WebQuest from <http://education.nmsu.edu/webquest/wq/software/index.html>

Do - Software Evaluation from <http://www.hsewebdepot.org/imstool/GEMI.nsf/WEBDocs/DoSoftwareEvaluation?OpenDocument>

Software Evaluation from <http://hagar.up.ac.za/catts/learner/eel/Conc/conceot.htm>

Web-based Standards of Learning Technology Initiative: Handbook for the Evaluation and Selection of Software for Instruction and Remediation, Division of Technology Office of Educational Technology from <http://www.pen.k12.va.us/VDOE/Technology/techinithandbook/>